Ops Room where more bad news awaited them. Information had just come in that the fighting had spread to Bomdila. The Battalion HQ of 5 Guards which had moved up to Thembang had reported over the wireless that the Chinese, coming in from the north, had surrounded their location. They had been granted permission to withdraw by 48 Brigade HQ.

Pathania had spoken to the BGS some time ago. He described the situation of 62 Infantry Brigade and his own HQ as very precarious as a result of roadblocks established by the Chinese and had pleaded for permission to withdraw. K. K. Singh had refused, and had advised the GOC to stay put. Thereupon Pathania had rung off.

Palit once again turned in desperate anguish towards Thapar and Sen. He was to write later (and his version was corroborated by others): 'I could scarcely believe what we were being told. None of the commanders seemed to have the heart for a fight. As soon as we were secluded in the corps' Ops Room, I remarked to Thapar, "Everyone seems to be withdrawing! As far as I can make out the Guards have not even been attacked, and yet they are being pulled out of battle. Their withdrawal will mean that the road from Bomdila to Dirang will be exposed to the enemy who would then be free to disrupt 4 Division's line of communication at will. This is a disastrous decision."'

Bogey Sen turned to K. K. Singh, but instead of giving him any definite orders, the Eastern Army Commander told the BGS he was no longer required and dismissed him. As K. K. Singh departed from what was his Ops Room, Palit once again confronted Sen: 'Sir, I hope you will reverse at least this decision. And if it is too late to stop the withdrawal, 48 Brigade commander must be ordered to re-establish a position on Thembang Ridge with fresh troops; or, at least, to position troops somewhere on the lower slopes of that ridge—to deny the enemy easy access to the main Tawang road.'

Bogey Sen said to Palit coldly: 'I've already told you, Monty, it is not my job to interfere in the corps' or the division's battles.'

'On the contrary, in the absence of the corps commander, you, by your very presence, are responsible for the corps' battle. It has reached a critical stage and it is for you to assume command.'

Sen just kept staring at his shoes, stubbornly refusing to say anything.

A desperate Palit turned to Thapar, who had barely even spoken since Sen informed him of the Chinese attack on Se-la: 'Sir, please take over the